

Advanced Radio License Notes

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1 Introduction

This are the notes from following the advanced course on HamRadio.au.

2 Electronics and Circuit Theory

2.1 Impedance

2.1.1 Introduction

Impedance is how a circuit stores or resists AC (or any changing) energy. If the impedances within a circuit aren't matched, then power gets reflected back instead of going where it is needed.

Impedance is the combination of resistance and reactance. Resistance is the restriction of the "flow" of energy, and converts that restricted energy to heat. This is measured in Ohms Ω . Reactance can be thought of as a flywheel, it stores energy temporarily and releases it. This is what capacitors and inductors do. This is also measured in Ohms. This means that impedance is the total opposition to current.

Why this matters. The transmitter expects to see 50Ω of impedance. The coax is also 50Ω . If the antenna isn't also close to 50Ω , then the power from the transmitter gets reflected, which is what SWR (standard wave ratio) measures.

2.1.2 Reactance

There are two types of reactance. One is found in inductors, and the other in capacitors.

Inductors (any coil of wire) opposes changes in current, i.e. their reactance increases with frequency

$$X_L = 2\pi fL.$$

This means that the higher the frequency, the more and inductor blocks the signal. This is why they are used in low-pass filters, they all for low frequencies but block high ones.

Capacitors opposes changes in voltage. Their reactance decreases with frequency

$$X_C = \frac{1}{2\pi fC}.$$

The higher the frequency, the easier it passes through the capacitors. This is why a capacitor in series blocks DC but passes RF.

2.1.3 Impedance formula

We can then write impedance as

$$Z = R + jX,$$

where R is the resistance, X is the impedance, and j is used in place of i for imaginary numbers due to i being used for current. The resistance part is where the energy is consumed, and the reactive part is where the energy is stored and returned. The total impedance is then given by the magnitude of this complex number

$$|Z| = \sqrt{R^2 + X^2}$$

Example. An antenna has $R = 50\Omega$ and $X = 25\Omega$. The total impedance magnitude is

$$\begin{aligned} Z &= \sqrt{2500 + 625} \\ &= \sqrt{3125} \\ &\approx 56\Omega \end{aligned}$$